

HEMANT CHAWLA



Caught in a Tit-for-Tat

DELHI It's payback time. Eager to pay the BJP back for its smear campaign against the new President Pratibha Patil, the Congress is now dredging up juicy details from Najma Heptullah's past. The Congresswoman-turned-BJP member is the saffron party's candidate for vice-president. "We may not have the numbers but we want to give the Congress a fight and not a walk-over. We chose Najma over others not because of her gender or religion but because of her impeccable character," said BJP leader Sushma Swaraj,

while circulating a copy of Heptullah's biodata and a letter of appeal seeking the support of MPs across party lines.

Heptullah's ex-colleagues are distributing a biodata as well—newspaper clippings on her less commendable exploits which include the controversial morphing of a photograph in a book showing Heptullah with freedom fighter Maulana Abdul Kalam Azad. The picture was aimed at flaunting her "proximity" to Azad, but the original photograph showed Azad with the Shah of Iran.

CHOSEN ONE: Heptullah

Stung by BJP questioning Sonia Gandhi's ability to make the right choice, the Congress now wants to give it back the same way.

But BJP insiders are also questioning the decision to field Heptullah. One view is that it would have made more sense to appeal to the party's vote-bank and field an upper caste Hindu rather than a candidate from a community that never votes for the party. Heptullah was chosen over NDA allies like Sharad Joshi and Charanjit Singh Atwal who were keen to contest. Swatantra Bharat Party's Joshi had argued that choosing him, a farmers' leader, would be beneficial to counter the UPA's vote-bank politics.

When Swaraj suggested Heptullah's name, others agreed in the hope that her tenure as deputy chairperson of the Rajya Sabha will win them some cross-party votes. The vice-presidential polls may not be as high-profile as the presidential one, but they seem to be equally murky.

by Priya Sahgal

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: **Shekhar Dutt** as the deputy National Security Adviser for dealing with strategic and defence-related subjects.

DIED: **Kazi Lhendup Dorjee Khang Serpa**, 103, the first chief minister of Sikkim from 1974-79. One of the founders of democracy in the state, he was instrumental in the merger of Sikkim with the Indian Union and was conferred with the Padma Vibhushan and Sikkim Ratna.

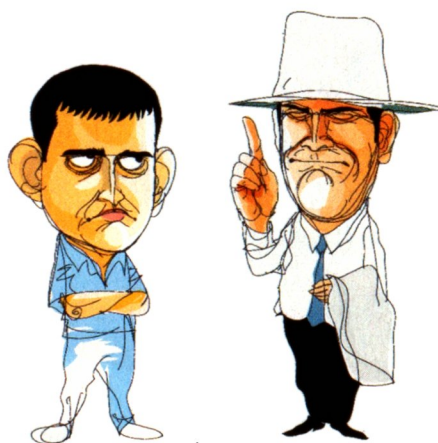


DIED: **Dilip Ganguly**, 58, senior journalist and East India correspondent of Associated Press. He covered the Gulf War, the Rwandan genocide and terrorist activities in Kashmir.

APPOINTED: **Lt. General Deepak Kapoor** as the new Chief of Army Staff. He succeeds General J. J. Singh. He was commissioned into the Regiment of Artillery in 1967.

VIS-A-VIS **SOURAV GANGULY** cricketer **versus** **SIMON TAUFEL** Australian umpire

“
I was
disappointed
when I came back to
the dressing room.
Some decisions go
your way, some go
the other way.
”



SAURABH SINGH

“
I would have given
Ganguly out every
time. As the ball
crossed his bat
there was a sound.
Even non-striker
Laxman heard it.
”

EPILOGUE: Decisions in cricket can't surely be based just on sound. How about using eyes too?